HEART · METHODOLOGY

Creation of a Psychological Immersive Theatre

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Problem and Relevance

Many people face challenges in communication, emotional control, self-awareness, and understanding of the world. They often experience unresolved psychological trauma and incomplete gestalts. Traditional psychological approaches can be intimidating, unengaging, and ineffective, sometimes disregarding the emotional aspect entirely. This leads to a reluctance to seek help, prejudiced attitudes towards psychology, and skepticism towards therapy.

Theatrical performances are often purely for entertainment. Why not combine business with pleasure? Create a unique space where theater, psychology, and body-oriented psychotherapy converge to help reframing perceptions, motivating action, promoting reflection, healing wounds, processing trauma, and acquiring new skills.

> *A place where, after visiting, you leave feeling like a new person.*

Objective

To create a psychological theatre that aims to educate, help individuals discover themselves, promote personal development, and address psychological issues through a customized approach.

We aim to create a safe and inclusive environment where individuals can explore their emotions, develop emotional intelligence, and find new ways to grow. Our theatre will utilize theatrical techniques, psychological principles, and therapeutic methods to achieve these goals.

Tasks

01 ### Develop a theater concept

This includes: the name, definition of the mission, target audience, formats and methods of work, and development of safety rules.

02 **Form the methodological basis for the project.**

This involves studying and synthesizing psychotherapy methods, acting techniques, and social and communication approaches.

03 **Create structure and content for group programs.**

This entails developing step-by-step lesson plans and selecting exercises, as well as providing a specific example.

04 **Design tools for working with clients.**

Creating a questionnaire for participants and a feedback system to track progress is included in this step.

05 **Test the methodology through practice by creating and describing a specific case.**

Developing an individual performance session for a client (John, age 32) with the fear of public speaking based on the knowledge and experiences of others is part of this step, considering their unique needs.

Topics for study

- Fundamentals of general and clinical psychology
- Methods and directions of psychotherapy
- Professional ethics and boundaries
- Theatrical pedagogy and directing
- Social theatre and participatory theatre

Further tasks

- Recruiting a team
- Preparing props and space
- Conducting interviews with psychologists/coaches
- Organizing and facilitating brainstorming sessions with the team
- Hosting free public masterclasses
- Creating content demonstrating the methodology
- Supervision and ongoing refinement

Theatre Concept

NAME	HEART
MISSION	To promote self-awareness, enhance personal qualities, overcome fears and inhibitions, and address psychological challenges through individual and group activities using theatre techniques, psychological principles, and therapy methods. A safe and inclusive space where professionals support individuals through theatrical activities, performances, psychological support, and therapeutic interventions.
TARGET AUDIENCE	Individuals of all ages.

Format · 1. Individual Sessions

A deep and personalized process focused on one individual's

- needs
- mental and physical state
- life experiences
- psychological triggers, trauma
- other relevant factors, identified through several in-depth interviews.

Based on a thorough analysis, a specific goal is set, such as overcoming fear of public speaking, gaining confidence, or learning how to say "no". Psychotherapy techniques, such as drama therapy, gestalt therapy, and cognitive-behavioral therapy, are used to help the client achieve these goals.

Theater techniques, including Stanislavski's system, improvisation, and Meyerhold's biomechanics, as well as social-communicative approaches like immersive theater and non-violent communication, are used to create a unique scenario with roles, situations, words, objects, and smells that are tailored to the client's personal significance.

In a safe and intimate environment, clients "live through" and experience this new experience physically. This format ensures deep immersion in the circumstances, sometimes in uncomfortable settings, based on a detailed analysis. It provides a personalized "sandbox" for personal change, acknowledging each person's uniqueness.

> *The client is not just an observer, but a co-creator and participant.*

Foundations of General and Clinical Psychology

Psychology studies the human mind through interactions with the environment.

General psychology explores how cognitive processes, states, patterns, and mental properties arise and develop. It synthesizes various research to form principles, methods, and core concepts. The main focus is on memory, character, thinking, temperament, perception, emotions, sensations, and more.

It examines cognitive processes, personality development within and outside society, and interpersonal relationships. The findings from general psychology form the basis for all psychological disciplines.

Modern psychology is a multidisciplinary field, divided into fundamental and applied branches. Fundamental psychology identifies facts, mechanisms, and laws of mental activity. Applied psychology studies psychological phenomena in natural settings, drawing on fundamental principles.

Clinical psychology investigates mental processes and behavior related to illness and disorder. It involves diagnosing, preventing, and correcting mental and psychosomatic issues to aid adaptation and recovery. Main activities include:

- Consulting
- Diagnosing and identifying deviations, developmental issues, and risks
- Psychocorrection and psychotherapy techniques
- Psychological hygiene
- Rehabilitation and social adaptation
- Educational and preventive work

Clinical psychologists work with a variety of conditions, including

- anxiety
- neuroses
- mood swings
- addictive behaviors
- suicidal tendencies
- trauma, depression
- psychosomatic symptoms (following a medical evaluation)
- exhaustion
- sleep, and appetite issues

Psychotherapy and Methods

Psychotherapy is a science-based approach to psychological intervention that aims to help individuals resolve emotional, personal, and social challenges. Its goal is not to provide ready-made solutions, but rather to enable clients to better understand and manage their difficulties, alter negative patterns, boost self-esteem, and enhance their quality of life.

Methods used include:

- **Cognitive-behavioral techniques**, which involve identifying and altering negative thoughts and beliefs
- **Art therapy**, which allows individuals to express emotions through drawing, sculpting, music, and dance
- **Body-oriented therapy** (addressing physical tension linked to emotional issues)
- **Group therapy** (using group dynamics to facilitate healing)
- **Psychodrama** (role-playing and enactment)
- **Hypnotherapy** (using hypnosis for anxiety, stress, phobias)

A clinical session involves psychodiagnostics (to assess mental function impairments) and symptom management (psychocorrection). The psychologist does not prescribe medication or diagnose, but monitors progress.

Long-term psychotherapy aims at deep personal change:

- habit correction
- emotional regulation
- communication skills
- self-awareness

Professional Ethics and Boundaries

CONFIDENTIALITY	All personal stories shared within the group remain private. Discussions outside sessions are prohibited unless with client consent.
“STOP” RULE	Participants can say “Stop” at any time if uncomfortable or wishing to pause.

NON-JUDGMENTAL COMMUNICATION	Focus on feelings ("I felt anxious when...") rather than judgments ("You did it wrong").
RESPECT FOR BOUNDARIES	Participants may choose not to disclose information. Physical contact is only allowed with consent.

> The facilitator is not a psychotherapist and does not deal with deep trauma or mental illness. Clients are advised to seek professional help if necessary.

Theatre Pedagogy and Directing

Stanislavsky System

- **Given circumstances** — immersing in the character's context (who am I? where am I? what is my background?)
- **Super-objective** — the main goal of the character
- **Emotional and physical memory** — recalling real emotions to create an authentic performance

Meyerhold Method

- **Biomechanics** — exercises to develop balance, rhythm, and reaction, simplifying complex actions into basic movements
- **Play theatre** — actors remain aware that they are acting and do not lose the role

Chekhov's Psychophysical Approach

- Treats the mind and body as one entity, where movement is related to sound and emotion.
- Develops creative thinking for character development beyond personal experience
- **Psychological gesture:** an unconscious physical expression of internal states (e.g., shrinking due to insecurity)
- **Improvisation:** fostering spontaneity and dialogue without preparation

Social Theatre and Engagement Theatre

Forum Theatre (Augusto Boal)

An interactive approach to addressing social issues. Participants act out problems and collaboratively find solutions, empowering individuals with skills and emotional intelligence to solve real-life challenges.

Immersive Theatre

A contemporary form where the audience becomes "immersed" in the action. Unlike traditional theatre, the stage is removed, placing spectators directly in the environment, often using significant architecture or elaborate set design to facilitate direct interaction with performers and surroundings, breaking the "fourth wall."

Playback Theatre

An improvisational performance where audience members share personal stories and actors transform them into theatrical scenes through improvisation, metaphors, voice, and movement. This helps viewers see situations from new perspectives.

Participant Questionnaire

1. Participant Information. “Heart”

Name: _____

Phone Number: _____

2. Your Goals

What is your goal for participating in this performance? Do you have any concerns or fears that you want to address? For example, fear of public speaking or learning to say "no".

3. Experience

Have you previously participated in psychological training or acting studios? If so, please describe your experience.

4. Health and Safety

Do you have any medical conditions, injuries, or phobias that we should be aware of?
Please let us know if there are any topics or situations that may be sensitive for you.

5. What are the signs that indicate the sessions are taking place in a safe and trustworthy environment for you?

Consent: agreement

I, _____, confirm that I am familiar with the rules (confidentiality, "Stop" rule, etc.) and understand that the facilitator is not a psychotherapist. I agree to participate.

Date: _____ Signature: _____

Example of a Personal Approach

To demonstrate practical application, we will use a hypothetical case. This scenario uses real techniques from drama therapy and acting, as well as various methods, reflecting typical stages in working with similar concerns.

CLIENT	John, age 32
REQUEST	Fear of Public Speaking

1. Initial Consultation

During the dialogue, we discussed the root cause of the problem, which was found to be the traumatic experience during adolescence. In my research on "Removing psychological and physical clamps before going on stage," I discovered that adolescence is a crucial period in a person's life that significantly influences their personality, views, and beliefs.

At the age of 13, John was standing at the blackboard during a math class with a new and strict teacher. He was feeling very nervous and his palms were sweating profusely. As a result, he accidentally dropped a box of chalk, causing it to fall on the floor in front of everyone in the class. The other children started laughing, and the teacher exclaimed, "Well, are your hands full of holes, little one? Be prepared!" This incident reinforced John's negative self-image, making him feel like a failure.

2. Therapeutic Approach

Drama therapy combined with Gestalt therapy using the "Empty Chair" technique.

Goal: Detach from the "inner critic" (teacher and classmates), gain control, and reframe the traumatic event through emotional processing and rewriting the ending.

3. Session Scenario

STEP 1. RELAXATION EXERCISES AND SAFETY PREPARATIONS

John is sitting on a comfortable sofa in a dimly lit room, listening to calm music. I ask him to close his eyes and use the "square breathing" technique (4 seconds in, 4 seconds hold, 4 out, 4 hold). This technique helps John to relax and focus on his breath, allowing him to feel more relaxed and centered.

After a few minutes, I ask John to stand up and feel the ground beneath his feet. I help him find a position that makes him feel confident and balanced, such as with his hands on his hips and feet shoulder-width apart. This helps him feel more grounded and in control of his body.

STEP 2. IMMERSION ROLE-PLAYING OF THE TRAUMATIC SCENE

**Noise, like in a classroom during a lesson*, a stern voice can be heard, "John, please come to the blackboard"*

We are in a brightly lit room, reminiscent of John's school classroom. It is similar to the situation he described during the interview.

John walks to the front of the room, but instead of standing in front of the board, he sits on a chair, facing the desks where his classmates used to sit. (He sits down, rather than standing, which subconsciously gives him more comfort and a sense of control.)

John is asked to talk about a neutral topic, such as his hobbies.

The noise does not stop, laughter can be heard, and John begins to feel nervous. After a minute, his voice starts to tremble and his palms become sweaty. He is transported back to the feelings of being a thirteen-year-old, being laughed at by the whole class. This is a physical response to the memory of a traumatic event.

STEP 3. EXPRESSING EMOTIONS AND EXPERIENCING THEM IN A SUPPORTIVE ENVIRONMENT

I tell John that his reaction was perfectly normal and that he can say anything he wants. These emotions were deep inside him and they weren't allowing him to live peacefully and be confident. He was influenced by these beliefs and they were not a part of who he really is.

We moved to another room with a cozy and secluded atmosphere. I placed a chair in front of John.

> **I said:** "John, right now, you are a scared thirteen-year-old boy. The whole class laughed at you just now, and you are filled with fear and shame. But you are sitting across from yourself as a thirty-two-year-old man who has accomplished many things. What would you like to tell that younger version of yourself?"

> **John replied:** "I'm scared that they will laugh at me forever. I want to cry but my body doesn't listen. I look so stupid. But I didn't mean to do it."

> **I responded:** "Yes, you were afraid and hurt. And you had every right to feel that way. Thank you for sharing that with me."

This is the key point. Finally, your feelings, thoughts, and emotions have been heard. Feeling compassion and sympathy for yourself at this moment is a completely normal and appropriate reaction.

STEP 4. ROLE REVERSAL. SELF-AWARENESS, FORGIVENESS.

I asked John to move to the chair across from me.

> **I (presenter):** "John, now imagine you're sitting across from yourself at the age of 13. As an adult, what would you want to say to yourself?"

> **John:** "Look, don't worry about it. You're doing great. This could happen to anyone. The classmates were just taking it as an excuse to laugh. They're still young and don't understand. Forgive them and don't take it personally. If anything, I'm here for you. You're stronger than you think and you're not a failure!"

John seemed calmer and even smiled. His words were important because he was speaking to himself.

STEP 5. "REWRITING THE SCRIPT"

We return to the classroom. I hand John the chalkbox again.

> **Me:** "Drop it and let's see what happens."

John drops the chalk. There's a pause. Instead of cowering and blushing, he looks at the chalk, then at the classroom, and exhales, shaking his head as if to say "well, it happens". His shoulders straighten.

> **Me:** "So what? The world didn't collapse. You're still here. You can just pick up the crayons, laugh with the class, and continue your answer. Everyone makes mistakes and that's okay."

And John does. A smile and relaxed expression appear on his face.

STEP 6. RESULT AND REFLECTION.

> *Insight I gained from John: "I realized I wasn't afraid of performing in front of people, but of repeating the humiliation. But I'm no longer that little boy. I'm a man who stands up for himself."*

As a homework assignment, John agreed to conduct the next meeting on his own at work. He decided to focus not on ensuring that everything goes perfectly, but on the effectiveness of information sharing. We agreed that his "victory" would not be a perfect speech, but rather the very act of voluntarily stepping in front of his colleagues with a new attitude.

Conclusion

This project has demonstrated the viability and potential of combining theater and psychology. The developed concepts and techniques create a unique environment for deep personal transformation. The project shows that theater can be not only art, but also a powerful tool. The work done made it possible to achieve the main goal - to develop a concept and methodological support for psychological (immersive) theater.

The prospects for the project's development are to test the methods on real audiences and further adapt programs to specific target groups.

> *This project is not just an academic exercise for me, it is something more.*

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